the region and, as happened in much of Indonesia and Malaysia, the local ruler adopted the faith. The converted Chams came to be known as the Bani, but a significant number retained their Hindu faith. They are known as the Bacam. The Bacam, along with the Balinese of Indonesia, are the only two surviving non-Indian Hindu populations in South-East Asia.

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In the 1940s, the American scholars John Fairbank and Teng Ssu-yu advanced the concept of the ‘tribute system’ as a uniquely Chinese East Asian order. This was described as a ‘set of ideas and practices developed and perpetuated by the rulers of China over many countries’. The term ‘tribute’ does not figure in Chinese political literature but has been happily embraced by modern China as a narrative of Chinese centrality and dominance over most of Asia. In Chapter 2, we examined the nature of the so-called tribute system and its rather thin connection with notions of political overlordship. None of the great empires of Asia recognized China as a superior political entity or considered themselves as vassals of China. Even as far as culture is concerned, Chinese influence is limited to a narrow periphery. There is no such thing as an Asian value system which is derived from Chinese Confucian values. There are many external and local cultural streams that have blended together to form the contemporary and rich cultures of East and South-East Asia. One could claim without exaggeration that the Indian imprint here is much more prominent than the Chinese one.